

HALO CAFÉ

UX Case Study

Designing a Digital Ordering Experience for a Local Café

PROJECT INFORMATION

COMPANY Halo Café (Concept)	ROLE Solo UX/UI Designer	PLATFORM Mobile & Desktop
COURSE INTD 251 – UX Research & Evaluation	RESEARCH METHOD Competitive Analysis	DELIVERABLES Wireframes, Design System, Prototype

How can a beloved local café thrive digitally without losing its soul?

Overview

Halo Café is a Chicago-based specialty coffee shop with a minimalist identity built around quality ingredients and a slow, intentional café experience. Despite a loyal local following, Halo had no digital presence — no website, no online ordering, and no way for customers to engage with the brand remotely. This project set out to design a full digital ordering experience for Halo across mobile and desktop platforms, grounded in competitive research and guided by the café's distinct brand voice.

Problem Statement

Halo Café operated exclusively in-person, leaving it invisible to customers who discover and order from local businesses online. Without a digital presence, the café risked losing relevance to competitors who offered seamless mobile ordering, loyalty perks, and brand storytelling through their digital channels.

"Minimal ingredients. Maximum craft. — but no way to order from your couch."

Focusing Question

How can we design a digital ordering experience that reflects Halo's premium, minimal brand identity while making it effortless for customers to browse, customize, and pay — wherever they are?

Research Insights

A competitive analysis of leading café and coffee ordering apps — including those from specialty and chain competitors — revealed three key patterns that informed the Halo design:

FINDING 1: FRICTION AT CUSTOMIZATION

Most café apps overwhelm users with customization options presented in cluttered, hard-to-scan layouts. Users frequently abandon orders mid-flow when too many choices are surfaced without visual hierarchy.

Halo's response: The product detail screen organizes customization into clear, labeled groups — Size, Milk, Sweetness, Ice, and Add-ons — using pill-style selectors that are easy to tap and visually calm.

FINDING 2: CHECKOUT COMPLEXITY

Competitors often require account creation or multi-step authentication before a user can complete a purchase, creating significant drop-off. Simpler guest flows consistently outperform gated ones for first-time orders.

Halo's response: The checkout flow was designed as a lightweight three-step sequence — cart review, contact info entry, payment — with no account creation required.

FINDING 3: WEAK BRAND STORYTELLING

Most ordering apps prioritize transactional efficiency at the expense of brand warmth. Specialty cafés in particular suffer when their digital experience feels generic or disconnected from their physical space.

Halo's response: The homepage and menu were designed to reinforce the café's editorial voice ("Coffee worth slowing down for"), with warm neutrals, serif accents, and generous white space that mirrors the in-store experience.

Product Recommendations

UX STRATEGY

- Guest-first ordering: Allow users to order without creating an account to reduce friction and abandonment.
- Progressive disclosure: Surface customization options only after a product is selected, keeping the menu screen clean and browsable.
- Brand-consistent microcopy: Use the café's editorial tone throughout — confirmation screens, empty states, and button labels should all feel like Halo, not a generic app.
- Newsletter and repeat touchpoints: Footer-level newsletter signup to capture customer relationships without interrupting the order flow.

UI ENHANCEMENTS

- Design system: Establish a cohesive token set covering color (warm neutrals + caramel accent), typography (serif display + sans-serif body), and a reusable component library for buttons, cards, and selectors.
 - Mobile-first responsive layout: The prototype was designed mobile-first, with a desktop version that adapts the card grid and navigation for wider viewports.
 - Customization pill components: Pill-shaped, toggle-style selectors for Size, Milk, Sweetness, and Ice reduce cognitive load versus dropdown menus.
 - Tip selection on payment screen: Offer 10%, 15%, and 20% tip options on the payment screen to normalize tipping in a digital context.
 - Order confirmation with time estimate: Closing the loop with a clear confirmation screen (order number + 20-minute pickup window) reduces post-order anxiety.
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End-to-End User Flow

The prototype covers the complete ordering journey across 7 screens:

- Homepage — Brand introduction, popular picks, and navigation to the full menu.
 - Menu — Tabbed categories (Coffee, Tea, Pastries, Seasonal) with product cards.
 - Product Detail — Item description, photo, customization options, and Add to Cart.
 - Cart — Order summary with item list, subtotal, tax, and total.
 - Checkout — Contact information collection (name, email, phone).
 - Payment — Tip selection and payment method (card or cash).
 - Order Confirmation — Order number and estimated pickup time.
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Design System

A lightweight design system was developed to ensure visual consistency across all screens:

- Color: Warm off-white background (#F5F0EB), near-black text (#1A1A1A), caramel accent (#C8A97E), and deep charcoal for navigation (#1A1A1A).
 - Typography: Serif typeface for display headlines (brand voice), sans-serif for UI body text and labels (legibility).
 - Components: Reusable button styles (primary CTA, ghost/outline), product cards, pill selectors, form inputs, and tab navigation.
 - Wireframes: Low-fidelity wireframes established layout and flow logic before visual design was applied.
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Results & Reflection

The Halo Café prototype demonstrates a complete, brand-coherent digital ordering experience designed from the ground up. Key outcomes of this project include:

- A functional, high-fidelity mobile and desktop prototype built in Figma.

- A reusable design system (color, typography, and component library) that could support future feature additions.
- A checkout flow reduced to three steps, informed by competitive analysis findings on drop-off.
- A brand experience that carries the café's minimalist identity from homepage through order confirmation.

Next steps for development would include usability testing with target users, accessibility audit (contrast ratios, tap target sizing), and exploration of a loyalty/rewards feature to encourage repeat ordering.